

“O Queen of the Holy Rosary”

Text: Emily M. C. Shapcote, 1889

Meter: 8.6.8.6 D

Suggested Tune: ELLACOMBE

1. O queen of the holy rosary!
Oh, bless us, as we pray
and offer thee our roses
in garlands day by day.
While from our Father's garden,
with loving hearts and bold,
we gather to thine honor,
buds white and red and gold.

2. O queen of the holy rosary!
Each myst'ry blends with thine;
the sacred life of Jesus
in ev'ry step divine.
Thy soul was His fair garden,
thy virgin breast His throne,
thy thoughts His faithful mirror,
reflecting Him alone.

3. Sweet lady of the rosary,
white roses let us bring
and lay them round thy footstool
before our infant king.
For, nestling in thy bosom,
God's Son was fain to be:
the child of thy obedience
and spotless purity.

4. Dear lady of the rosary,
red roses cast we down,
but let thy fingers weave them
into a worthy crown.
For how can we poor sinners
do aught but weep with thee
when in thy train we follow
our God to Calvary?

5. O queen of the holy rosary!
What radiancy of love,
what splendor and what glory
surround thy court above!

Oh, in thy tender pity
dear source of love untold,
refuse not this our offering:
our flow'rs white, red, and gold.

6. O queen of the holy rosary!
We share thy joy and pain,
and long to see the glory
of Christ's triumphant reign.
Oh, teach us holy Mary,
to live each mystery,
and gain by patient suff'ring
the glory won by thee.

Reflection (Feast of Our Lady of the Rosary):

This hymn is addressed to Mary, the queen of the holy rosary. The first verse speaks of us honoring her with daily offerings of roses, strung into garlands. This is a metaphor of the rosary, on which we offer Mary prayers from our hearts rather than roses from a garden.

Throughout the text, it is noteworthy that these offerings through the rosary are colored “white, red, and gold.” Since this text was written in the 19th century, the Luminous mysteries had not been invented yet, so there were only three sets of mysteries: Joyful, Sorrowful, and Glorious. These mysteries follow in the steps of Mary, allowing us to meditate on the central moments of Christ's life.

Firstly, verse 3 speaks of the “white roses,” representing the Joyful mysteries. When praying the Joyful mysteries, we reflect on Christ's incarnation and childhood – His time spent in the nurturing care of His mother.

Verse 4 speaks of the “red roses,” representing the Sorrowful mysteries. When praying the Sorrowful mysteries, we reflect on Christ’s passion and death. We weep with Mary watching His crowning with thorns, carrying of the cross, and crucifixion, all the while recalling our own sinfulness.

Finally, verse 5 erupts with a burst of praise celebrating the Glorious mysteries with confidence that Mary, who was assumed into heaven and crowned as queen, will accept and listen to our prayers. (Although the text never explicitly mentions it, by process of elimination we can conclude that the Glorious mysteries are represented by the gold roses.)

The final verse brings the whole text together. First, we tell Mary that, through the mysteries of the rosary, we have shared a part of the same moments that she experienced while watching her Son grow. Then, we ask for her help to follow her model of virtue until we, too, reach heaven.